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**GREATEST
INDIANS**
SPECIAL ISSUE

SCIENCE

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"My success will not depend on what A or B thinks of me. My success will be what I make of my work."

NUCLEAR MAHA

Creator of institutions, supporter of basic research and father of the country's atomic energy programme, he was a polymath

■ By Srikumar Banerjee

Homi Jehangir Bhabha, the architect of India's nuclear power programme, went to England to pursue an engineering degree. But his first love was basic research in science. He once said, "No country which wishes to play a leading role in the world can afford to neglect pure or long-term research." As a first step in his mission to make India a nuclear power, he set up the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research (TIFR)—a centre of excellence in basic science, in 1945. He went on to create the atomic energy programme of India in 1948. Thanks to him, India had the privilege of designing and constructing a research reactor almost 50 years ago.

Besides the atomic energy programme, he was also instrumental in initiating and nurturing India's space programme in the formative years. Bhabha could achieve his dream of India becoming a nuclear power as he had strong support and single-point clearance from the then prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru. He also acknowledged this fact: "Provided proper appreciation and financial support are forthcoming, it is one's duty to stay in one's own country and build schools comparable with those that other countries are fortunate in possessing."

When a reporter once asked Bhabha about his marriage, he said, "I am married to creativity". It was his style to create institutions of excellence around accomplished individuals. In a fitting tribute, the Atomic

